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Charles Calello

Arranger and producer Charlie Calello has played an integral role in iconic recordings since the mid-1960s. He has collaborated with The Four Seasons, Neil Diamond, Bruce Springsteen, and most recently Joe Bwarie.

Charlie was interviewed on July 21, 2025 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm with Charles Calello today which is a real thrill because you actually did what I wanted to do for a living. I just think that being an arranger is such a creative thing to do, and every week, every day you're presented with a different issue. Would you agree with that statement?

CC: Yeah well I started to do this as a hobby. I went to the Music & Arts High School and there was really talented, talented players at the age of 13 to 16 years old they were playing on a professional level. And the accordion player in the band, now we're going back to the '50s so the accordion was a common instrument. I was an accordion player. The accordion player in that band got a scholarship to Harvard and they needed an accordion player so I joined the band. And the first rehearsal they said, "Let's do 'Almost Like Being in Love.'" So the saxophone player said, "Charlie, give us the notes." I said, "What do you mean?" He said, "Well play something on the accordion." So I played [scats]. So he says, "Great," he says. "All right, give that to the trumpet, now give me a harmony." I said, "What do you mean?" He said, "Well give me your note that you would play underneath it." So I gave the – I listened to him and I says, "This is really cool."

MR: Yeah. And how would you know to play [scats], just that like was inside you from listening to the radio or something?

CC: Well my father was a musician, and I studied trumpet for a while. But my father wanted me to become an accordion player because the accordion players worked at bar mitzvahs and weddings and they always got paid extra because they worked extra hours or something. So my father wanted me to play the accordion. So I had knowledge of music from a very early age and my father, although he played club dates, had Miles Davis records in his collection. So as a kid I found them and I was sort of impressed over the fact that this music was appealing to me. And the first jazz record I heard was Miles – or it was Gerry Mulligan's arrangement of "Move." And I studied it and then as I went to high school and started to meet other musicians, I found out that there were people that actually played jazz. And I became interested in it, started to learn chords and things like

also writing – in school we were writing figured bass. So I had some knowledge as to, you know, what to do. But these were head arrangements. I wasn't writing anything out.

MR: So the accordion probably was a good thing to be playing because you were playing melodies and chords and bass notes, sort of like arranging as you went.

CC: Right. Well I also learned how to play the bass lines on the accordion, and then I had my accordion amplified and I worked with someone to get a low pass filter on the amp so I can get the depth like I have an organ. So in the '50s I had modified the accordion to where I could play it and get a sound that was close enough to an electric organ. And that was only after I heard Jimmy Smith play. And I wanted to sound like Jimmy Smith. So I learned how to play the bass lines with my left hand. And although we had a bass player in the band, he would put his bass down and sing some of the arrangements that I wrote. So I would be playing the bass line. And it was funny to see the musicians come in to look to see where the bass was coming from.

MR: I love that. You know I do that now but I do it on a keyboard and only rarely do I get – someone will, every once in a while say like, "Where's the bass coming from?" Or they'll say, "Hey you play a pretty good bass for a keyboard player." I like it. I think that in another life I was a bass player.

CC: Well when I went to high school I couldn't play accordion in band or orchestra so I started to play bass. And between playing bass and also playing accordion, it was an interesting start. At the age of 15, now this you'll get a kick out of – at the age of 15 there was a place in Atlantic City that the older musicians were playing in. The kids were like 17, 18 years old. And they got another job in another place and they needed a band to go to Eddie's Shamrock, which is on Kentucky Avenue. I was 15 going on 16, I got an ABC card, spent the summer in Atlantic City for 60 bucks a week, seven nights a week and two matinees. But here's what was cool: up the street was the Harlem Club, and also the jazz musicians in that area – I got a chance to see most of the jazz greats that came in, 15, 16 years old. I heard Ray Charles sing "Hallelujah" before the record came out. And so --

MR: All that like gets inside you I think, and later on you may not even remember where it came from but you use it.

CC: Well one of the things that I learned later on was I was not a great player. But musicians loved the arrangements and I knew how to make the arrangements sound great because of the accordion, because I could harmonize and play the in-between notes with the accordion so the chords would always sound full. And that was basically how I met Frankie Valli. He came into a club that I was working in. I had graduated high school. I was going to Manhattan School of Music and still working with a band. And he walked into a club, heard the band, and said, "Who wrote the arrangements?" And they pointed

MR: What did he particularly notice? Because -- did you have horn players? How large was the band?

CC: The band was five pieces. We had a trumpet player who played valve trombone and trumpet; and we had an alto player who played tenor; we had Fender bass, drums, and I played the accordion. So we also sang like the Four Freshmen and the Hi-Lo's. Now I copied some of the arrangements off the record. The first one we started with was "It's a Blue World," which was relatively easy, especially 'cause all the people in the band went to Arts High, they were all good musicians, they could read music, and as a result of it we could sing. So we rehearsed and we found out that we could actually sing and get a sound like the Four Freshmen. And then we did some of the tunes from the Hi-Lo's. So Frankie comes in, here's this band that was doing production numbers with two horns and also singing four part harmony. And he had a band called the Four Lovers. They had a hit record, or a chart record, on RCA in 1956. So everybody knew who Frankie Valli was in the city of Newark. But he had heard about my band, came to hear the band, and was amazed at how we sounded. So Frankie wanted me to join The Four Lovers. So I continued – I wanted to continue to go to school so I quit the band I was in and went to work with Frankie Valli and The Four Lovers playing bass. And the music that they did was sort of uninspiring and they didn't want to rehearse or change. They didn't have the musicality to do the things that we were doing with the other band. What was funny about it was all the musicians in town knew who we were. The name of the group was The Victorians. We couldn't draw six people. Frankie Valli played, they had a triad band that played like four chord songs and you couldn't get into the place.

MR: I have to write that comment down. "The triad band." No sevenths allowed.

CC: Yeah exactly. So although I learned that there was a different style of music that drew people, I still after work drove into New York, went to Birdland, you know saw Miles, Cannonball, Coltrane, Art Blakey. And there was also a jazz club in Newark called Sugar Hill and all the great jazz players came in. And I still followed, you know listened to jazz and was sort of drawn to do that. And in 1959 – well after The Four Lovers had their hit record Elvis became popular on RCA and The Four Lovers went on the back burner. So they lost their deal on RCA. We made a record when I was with The Four Lovers and we brought it to Bob Crewe. Bob Crewe ultimately became the producer of The Four Seasons. Bob had written "Silhouettes on the Shade," he also produced Freddy Cannon. So he was already an established producer making hit records. And he asked us if we wanted to be his studio band. And he would pay us ten dollars apiece, and we would come in to the studio at 11 or 12:00 at night and work all night because he can get the studio free. So we started to make records and I got an opportunity to start to make

music. He'd give me a record and say, "Charles I want the rhythm to sound like this. I want the horns to play this style, and I need strings. And here's what I want the strings to do." And he'd give me records to listen to.

MR: How did you know what strings were capable of? Was that from partly your high school education?

CC: I had no idea. Didn't have a clue. I mean I studied scores and I saw them. So now this is also interesting. Ariana Grande on the Tonight Show mentioned that – because I recorded her when she was twelve years old and wrote arrangements for her when she was seven with the Pops here in town. But she mentioned on the Tonight Show the first record I ever made with Bob Crewe. She found it and took the song and used it in one of her albums. And she said, "And my grandfather's best friend, Charlie Calello, and I saw his name on the record." So there was a little bit of a history behind that record. But now I had to write strings. Now at that point I'd never written for strings. I had only written for horns. And Bob gave me an idea and I also had some knowledge from looking at scores, but I really had no idea how quickly the string players would read it. So I wrote this arrangement and it was only for three violins, and it basically was all in unison. And it had runs in it. And I went to the studio, I was panicked. And I can't tell you – I kept saying to myself I know this is going to – I can't believe that it's going to sound good. I put it in front of them, they played it on sight and the second pass through they recorded it. And then because we were double tracking they played it a couple of times. I'm listening and I says, "God, that sounds great." So understanding that there was a song that Peggy Lee recorded, I don't know if you remember, it was "Is That All There Is?"

MR: Indeed.

CC: And I left the studio and I said, "That wasn't hard, it was really a lot of fun."

MR: God that's great.

CC: So then obviously when The Four Seasons became successful I became the arranger which gave me opportunity, and then my name was on records. And making a Four Seasons record, one of the – the drummer, Buddy Saltzman, who played on pretty much all The Four Seasons' hits, said to me, "Charlie," he said, "there's going to be four stages to your career." He said: Who's Charlie Calello? We have to get Charlie Calello. What we need is a young Charlie Calello. And whatever happened to Charlie Calello.

MR: Well I'm glad to have you here. Here's what happened. That's terrific. Was there a point where you said, "Hmm, I should be getting paid for this, and how much, and how do I charge?"

CC: Well I wrote the arrangements to the "Big Girls Don't Cry" album for ten bucks apiece.

MR: And you don't ever get any licensing or royalties for that, is that correct?

CC: No, later on as a producer I did but I was pleased to, you know, to get paid. Because I was writing arrangements for nothing. And there were a couple of interesting things about it. Bob was using another arranger, but he found out that not only I could do the same job but I could work cheaper, which I didn't know about. Then I found out that I should really ask him for more money because I was overloaded with stuff and it was starting to become a real job.

MR: With pencil and score paper, right?

CC: Pardon?

MR: Pencil and score paper?

CC: Right. Right.

MR: Did you write your own parts?

CC: Yes. No at that point, at that point he introduced me to a copyist. And also a little history with the copyist, he wound up copying most of the music for the Boston Pops. Because Richard Hayman was a client of his. Later on in life I started writing arrangements for Richard Hayman, who I became good friends with and became the assistant conductor of the orchestra here in Boca Raton that he had for many years.

MR: Did you write your scores in concert pitch or did you transpose the transposing instruments in the score?

CC: I wrote them transposed. In fact before you called I was doing, I found the original arrangement to "All By Myself" that I did with Eric Carmen. Eric died about a year ago and they're doing a tribute to him with the symphony. And it was originally a seven minute record and I couldn't find the long version of it so I have the hand written arrangement that we used to the record, so I'm transcribing it into Finale and then I'm going to fill in the parts that are missing. There's about three minutes of the arrangement that I can't seem to find. I have a copy of it, and if I could share the screen I could show you what it looked like with the hand-looking part looked like to "All By Myself." Because I've got it handy.

MR: Yeah. When we were corresponding through e-mail to set up this session you said, you wrote, "I've just finished a project and delivered the music on Sunday." So my curiosity is how has delivering the project, the music, changed from the '60s until now for you?

CC: Well when I said I delivered the music I worked on a record with the girl I work with. In fact tonight she's doing a performance at Birdland. And she did this record with the Count Basie band and I had to modify the arrangements for three horns, because she couldn't use the big band. So there were 15 arrangements that had to be re-written. So for small projects like that I would – it's impossible to do the – it just becomes cost prohibitive if you get a copyist to do them so I sort of have a fee that I do them all myself

and I have the printed parts and she lives up the street. So I drove ten minutes up the street and dropped them off.

MR: Did you have the Basie scores to work from or did you have to use your ear?

CC: No I had the scores but there were a lot of mistakes in them and a lot of things that the musicians played that weren't in the parts. And some of the arrangements – in fact it was difficult to try to work it out because a lot of the piano parts only had chords so if she went to perform where the piano wasn't playing for four bars, there were rests. So I mean it'd have to be modified.

MR: Yeah. I have a score or two that just crack me up because the arranger instead of writing "first alto" or whatever, they'd actually put the names down of the guys.

CC: Right.

MR: And I just – that's history man, I love it.

CC: Yeah well there were a couple of them that were written that way too.

MR: What possessed you – I'm wondering if there was an Aha! moment or – because I was looking at the Top 10 list of various years. And in the late '50s, early '60s there was such a variety of things. In 1949 you had "Bird with Strings" and then 1950 the "Third Man Theme," and Nat King Cole, Roger Williams, "Rock Around the Clock." Did some particular tune or style make a big impression on you?

CC: That's a good question because prior to me going and playing in the bar when I was 15, I remember over the summer I started to listen more closely to the radio. And I heard The Four Freshman sing "Day by Day." And I went and I bought the record. And also I heard Johnny Ray sing "Cry" and "The Little White Cloud that Cried." In fact I actually wrote an arrangement that I really, really liked for Ronnie Milsap with a big band and strings of the song "Cry" which actually became, for a while it was like a favorite, my favorite go-to one to play for my friends. But my background was sort of eclectic because my mother listened only to country music. And my father, being a musician, would listen to WNEW which would play Sinatra and those type records. So my exposure when I was like 10 to maybe 13 was sort of very eclectic. I didn't realize it then but eventually all these things would eventually play into something that I didn't realize that I had a gift and I can't take credit for it, it's something – you know every now and then you look on the internet and you see some kind four years old that could play Beethoven and you say oh my God how could they do that. And there's no logical way to explain it other than it's a gift. But I didn't recognize my gift until I was in my 60s. Because if you've written arrangements one of the things you realize is that you write an arrangement and it's never what you want. You never get it to be what – there's always something that you just struggled with and for years I'd listen to records on the radio and, "Oh I should have written this, I

really reach. And as a result of it I didn't realize that the true gift was not writing the notes on the paper, it was coming up with the idea. And for some reason instinctively I was gifted to come up with ideas. Like The Four Seasons – we needed an intro and there was scuffling. So I go to the piano on "Candy Girl" and I played this. I played four chords and I says, "How's this?" They said, "What did you do?" And the take "Dawn (Go Away)," which was written as a folk song and make it sound like it was an uptempo song with a different rhythm, different chord changes. And I realized only later on that my true gift was coming up with the idea and making the idea and turning them into records, where I didn't really write to please me as much as I wrote to try to invoke a feeling in the audience I was writing for.

MR: You know who said something very similar was Ray Conniff.

CC: Yeah?

MR: He was writing for big bands and he was very happy doing it but he was writing for the guys he said. And then he got interested, the band leader got interested, he said, "Write some bop for us." He said, "Naa I don't want to." And then he was out of work. And he thought you know I've been writing for the musicians, what if I wrote for the people who are buying the records. And I'm so happy to hear you say that. And I don't know if you recall but we had a phone conversation about a year ago and I saved my notes. And you said, "I wait for the song to talk to me."

CC: Ah, yes. And you know this is the fiftieth anniversary of Bruce Springsteen's "Born to Run" album. And I wrote the strings on "Jungleland." And the first time I really realized that I had to wait for the song to talk to me was when I wrote that arrangement. Normally I could write an arrangement for strings, a couple hours. So I went down to my office in New Jersey, to my basement. And I said I've got to write two arrangements for the session tomorrow. I started at 11 o'clock and I figured I'd be writing until two in the morning, I'd knock them off. It took me six hours to write that arrangement because I finally listened to the song. And I finally listened to where the record was going. And I met with Bruce. And Bruce knew he wanted strings on the record but really couldn't identify exactly what he wanted. In fact in the meeting he just, after ten minutes he says, "No, you do it." He says, "I'll see you tomorrow." But what was really interesting about it is eventually I started to hear what I needed to put on the record. And it sort of changed the way I approached writing string arrangements. But that was a process that was coming because I had made several arrangements that I remembered I just had to sit there and wait for it to come.

MR: Was it partly the lyric content that led you in the direction?

CC: I can't really say that it was any one thing. For many years I recorded Roberto Carlos,

piano, or on a keyboard, that he had recorded. And I heard him singing in Portuguese but he would tell me what it meant in English. And as he would tell me the story I could get the feeling of what he was saying. And the interesting part about – I learned about making records is when you listen to a record you may not remember what the lyric says. You may not remember what the melody was all at one time. But you'll really remember how it made you feel. So the whole idea was to get you to feel exactly what I felt making the arrangement. And if I could sit there and get chills when I was writing and say, "Oh I can't wait to hear this," I knew my enthusiasm being pored into the paper would eventually evoke a feeling in somebody else because we all feel joy, we all feel love, we all feel all these passions. And well maybe you didn't get it, but that person will get it, and maybe that person will get the feeling but there'll be two other people here that didn't get it. And that was a process of going through and learning that if it killed me when I was writing it, then I could just say, "Well what have you been doing, Charlie?" Say, "Hey check this out." And I knew that, because they were on the same plane, if they heard it they would get the same feeling.

MR: That's a great statement. Did you start to write – I'm going to re-phrase. When you first started to write did you need to be at the sessions so that if things went awry or a note needed to be fixed you were there for it. And then to make it a point where you didn't have to be there anymore.

CC: I wrote – all the arrangements I wrote I conducted on the session. I never wrote for anyone to go into – well maybe once or twice that may have happened but it wasn't a primary thing in my career. There were times I wrote arrangements that I didn't get credit for which – and one was "All By Myself." The artist took the credit for the arrangement and when the musicians in the band were looking for the score they knew who to call.

MR: You can't see this but I'm looking at the wall in front of me and I have a printout of the top 100 Charlie Calello hits and arrangements. And I've zoomed in on a couple. And I want to sort of dissect the "Lover's Concerto" if you don't mind. Because as you said, this hit a nerve with me. And I noticed that, I really got into the deep end with this because I was timing, how long was the melody. And you know the first phrase is like 16 seconds, and then there's two of them. A 16 second intro and then the whole first verse I'll call it, is 46 seconds. So part of an arrangement is like well we need more than a minute of music here. So we have to stretch this out. And was it your idea to go through five keys?

CC: No. In fact when I made that record – I'll back up a couple of beats – Sandy Linzer wrote the song with Denny Randell. Sandy Linzer also wrote "Dawn (Go Away)" with Bob Gaudio, and he became one of the writers of the Four Seasons. My father actually

decided to produce a record on their own. So I would sit with them and they would play me the song and then I would write the arrangements while they were sitting there. And what was interesting about it was we worked on the arrangements together. But now I did something that I didn't realize I did. On the introduction where it started with the concerto [scats] – right after that I wrote the intro to "Stop In The Name of Love." What was it – and unconsciously I wrote it because it went like this [scats]. And when I heard it on the radio I said to myself how could you do that. But the funny part about it – the funny part about it – it just needed something there and it seemed to fit the groove. And we never got busted for it, nobody ever called it to my attention. And as I would remind people about it they'd say, "Oh yeah it really does that." But now when they played me the song they played me the modulations. My father actually played trumpet on that record. But this was really funny, it was the fourth song on the session, to give you some idea of how quickly we made the record. Vinnie Bell, who was one of the guitar players on the session said, "Charlie, you've got five minutes. Are you going to get this fourth song done?" So I said, I said, "Yeah, let's do it right now." So I played the intro, only the intro and first verse, just to get the feel. And I said to the engineer, "Record it." It was the first take. There was only one take on the track. So when we finished the record, you know we didn't have the singers on yet, but the pop song that we were looking to release we finished it. It still sounded great but it was never released and eventually it was a hit by another group, a group from Australia, I forget the name of the song. But "A Lover's Concerto" was like the fourth song on the date. It wasn't something that we intended to even release as a single.

MR: It's curious, it's one of the few – there's a very short list of pop tunes that have titles that are never said in the lyrics.

CC: Right, right.

MR: Did they have that – that was their title at that point?

CC: Yeah. And Sandy – Sandy Linzer wrote the lyric and in my opinion is really, really, really a brilliant lyric writer. He's written a lot of hits, all different types of hits. And he's written pop hits all the way up until the Backstreet Boys. So when you have somebody who is that prolific as a kid and has a sensitivity, if you read the story, the story is – it doesn't sound like it was written by a guy that had that kind of emotion.

MR: That's true.

CC: But he went on to write many, many brilliant songs.

MR: At that time what was the technology in a good studio? How many tracks were you –

CC: Four track.

MR: And you had two inch – one inch tape?

CC: No it was half inch tape. Four track was half inch. And basically we would cut the tracks and sometimes we'd use two tracks. We'd put the rhythm on one track, the horns on another track. Sometimes we would record on all four tracks then mix it down and sort of overdub on top of it. But we were sort of in the embryonic stages of piecing records together as opposed to doing them live.

MR: I have a rather silly anecdote. Years go I was in a dentist's office. And they had a radio station on and I kept thinking something's off here. And you know it was low, I couldn't – and then a Four Seasons record came on. And I'm going, all I'm hearing is the singing. And what it was is one of their speakers was out. So I'm like oh my God, they were like panned hard left and hard right. That was on purpose I guess.

CC: Well the way we would record The Four Seasons, we'd record a track and then we'd overdub on the track, and then after we did all the overdubs on track we'd mix it down to a mono and put the mono – we'd copy it onto the four track. Then we would do the background voices. The background voices were done without the lead. So we would do the background voices, then we would do sound on sound. As we were recording the double track we would be doing it in conjunction with playing, so now we have two tracks. Frankie would then sing the lead and if he had to double he still had the track to double, again sound on sound, and we'd have one track to do strings and horns. So back then the four tracks only made mono records. So when stereo came out to try to re-create it, the only thing that they did was they split it up sort of crazy. But the early Four Seasons records sound best as monos.

MR: Did you at the time, that you and the engineers – I think I know the answer to this, but did you ever speculate like, "Oh, if we only had" and fill in the blank, like that piece of gear that's sitting behind you. If we only had more tracks. If we only could do this.

CC: Well it's funny about inventions. You know you didn't know you needed a can opener until somebody put one together. You know you'd go and you'd figure out maybe I'll get a screwdriver or whatever it was. I'm using this as a sort of ridiculous kind of illustration. But the fact is you don't know you need something until somebody shows up with it and says, "Oh boy this is handy."

MR: And you're in the digital world now.

CC: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Is it harder to know when to stop? Because basically you can keep tweaking things to infinity.

CC: Well I worked with some people that go past it. We get to the point where they should stop and they're still looking to improve it so I developed the phrase, "Well what do you think? Is this better?" I would say, "It's not better, it's different." So it got to a point

was not enough to affect the feeling. So as a result of a lot of insecurities, people that I worked with that were producers wound up doing things and worked past where they should have stopped, where they had the record, they just went past it and lost it, lost the record.

MR: Oh dear. And isn't there a budget in play here with most projects? Like okay we have to stop now, you're over budget and this record is now done.

CC: Well there was a time, well take into consideration "The Lover's Concerto" session cost $3,000. Okay? Right now if I go to make a record and I make some of the records in the range of right now we could do them by just cutting out – we do them for about $10,000 a song. But really a budget for like a Buble record or something like that is about twenty thousand a song. So if they do ten, twelve songs, you're looking at $250,000. Years ago we used to knock it off, "Lightnin' Strikes" was a $3,000 session. "The Name Game" was a $3,000 session. I'd cut the track – I'd cut the track with the background voices, put the voice on, and I was finished with the record, I was finished with "The Name Game" the same day and heard it on the radio that night.

MR: That doesn't happen today.

CC: No. Also I recorded, I had two chart records with Bobby Vinton. Bobby sang live with the orchestra in the room and the engineer played the mix back as we left the studio and that was the record. It was actually mixed. And that was the record.

MR: Speaking of "Lightnin' Strikes," this is from about two weeks ago, Lou Christie passed away. *New York Times* obituary and this – I'll read a bit of it, a small bit. "February 1966 with 'Lightnin' Strikes' chart topper marked by a sweeping arrangement by the producer Charles Calello featuring glimmering piano, ringing church bells, and radiant backing vocals from a vocal trio, The Delicates." I think that's really hip, that the *New York Times* mentioned the arranger.

CC: Well we actually made that record at the piano. The group that we used were The Angels – Peggy Farina, they had the hit record, "My Boyfriend's Back," but we used them as background singers. And they sang on all the records I did with Lou Christie. And we would get together, because they didn't read music, and we would work the record out around the piano. So before I would go into the studio I knew what the record was going to sound like. There was the one thing that I didn't anticipate was the guitar solo. The guitar player did it as an overdub and he played the guitar solo on a bass guitar. And also, what I did was after I laid out the records I gave them to Artie Schroeck to orchestrate. Now Artie was doing my sessions. I said, "Here's what we're going to do. I want you to use the two baritone saxes, a bass trombone, the rhythm section, and here are the tracks. Just copy this and put it on the record." So although I arranged it, he did the

orchestration. And the reason why I did it, as a producer I had the record made. If there was something somebody could bring to the table I wanted to have it.

MR: Well he brought some low end to that, with –

CC: That was a technique that I developed when I was doing "The Name Game." What I did was I had two baritone saxes and a bass trombone play octaves and fifth – and a fifth. They were like musical power chords. And what was interesting about "The Name Game" if you listen to the record it's sort of fun to analyze because the rhythm was like [scats] but the bass never played that. The bass played [scats]. So what happened was, with my short Schillinger education I learned that you could actually take different rhythms and make them work against one another. So while the low end was doing like [scats] they're going [scats]. And then with the African drums and everything, it was such a cool record to make. So I had established all those sounds, and this became like sort of my staple orchestra at that time. It's just like as the music changed the instrumentation changed. In the '70s, well after the '60s, when the music started to change, the orchestrations started to change. I started to listen to the Bee Gees records and when I did the arrangement to "Sweet Caroline" and wrote the bomp-bomp-bomp I took the instrumentation from a Bee Gees record. The Bee Gees were using two trumpets, two trombones and strings. And I thought that a lot of the songs that I was getting asked to arrange sounded like they fit the Bee Gee bag. So I started to use that instrumentation.

MR: Go ahead.

CC: Later on as the types of music changed, the orchestrations would change. And how the records would be put together would be determined by the style and what was being played on the radio.

MR: I believe I read that Neil Diamond gave you a sort of a wishy-washy compliment on your work for "Sweet Caroline."

CC: Yeah when I walked out of the studio I says, "How was that Neil?" He says, "Well I didn't hear anything wrong with it."

MR: "Well can I have a raise on that?" I had a fascinating chat with Bucky Pizzarelli once about, you know all the studio work he did. Because I noticed sometimes there'd be upwards of three or more guitars. And he said the guys sort of had worked out, you know one's going to do [scats] and one's going to play big chords and the other is little lines. Did you like to see particular players in the studio that knew that kind of thing?

CC: Here's what – see because I never did anybody else, I never went to anybody else's sessions. So as an arranger I had no idea what other guys did. I only knew what they did on the records. So in order to control the speed of how we can get the feel, I started to write the guitar parts out. I would write the rhythms and I would write some of the licks.

basically when I used three guitars or four guitars, I wrote the parts out. Not the little – like I would write the rhythms and I'd indicate when they should play where. And I didn't realize I did that until I went to California and I came back to New York after about a year and a half later and I did an orchestra date. And one of the guitar players said to the other guitar player, who was like Lou, doing sessions, he said, "See I told you, Calello used to write the parts out." So, and I heard him say that and what was funny was I didn't really understand it. Because to me this is the way I worked.

MR: You didn't know you were doing something that most other people didn't.

CC: Yeah. But how I learned, in order for me to get the style, what I would do periodically is I would go into the studio for – somebody wanted to record like ten songs and they wanted to do it for a project or something, I wouldn't write the arrangements, I would go in with chord sheets, which is how we used to make The Four Seasons records quickly. I'd write a – we called them a "PBA" or "PBG" – piano, bass, guitar. And I would write the main figures, the breaks, and they'd know where the cuts were and then we'd give the parts out, "Now you do this and that, and you do this and that." And then we would talk it out. And what I would do periodically, by doing that and giving it to the musicians, I would hear what the new licks were and what the new styles were that they would put – and I would do that. And then what I'd do is, "Oh they played this but I want that here." I don't like – I don't want them to do this, I want them to do it here. So then I would learn the little things that they would do and figure out where I wanted them in the arrangement.

MR: Am I correct that you would not change your arranging style if you were also the producer?

CC: This – that's a very interesting question because up until 1968 I made Charlie Calello records. I went in and did Charlie Calello. I didn't know I was doing it but I'd get called and I'd do this. This is what I did. The first time I realized I had to make somebody else's record was when I did the Laura Nyro "Eli" record. I met with Laura and she was very, very different. She wrote songs where in the middle of the song the feel would change. The tempo would change. She'd slow down. She'd play songs that didn't need instruments. And then they'd need something. And I figured out that in order for me to make her record I had to find out what the songs really, really needed. And that was the start of getting to that point. Now this was '68. By the '70s I had pretty much gotten to the – but I didn't have the realization that this is what I was doing. But I learned how to take the song and the artist and try to record and not make a Charlie Calello record as much as try to make the artist's record. It was sort of like if you listen to a Nelson Riddle arrangement, as soon as it starts you could tell it's Nelson. Just the way he put things together. And later on when he did the record he did for that female singer, I forget her

record. There was a thing that he did that made Nelson a brilliant record maker and brilliant arranger. Now I had no idea that when I played my arrangements I had people that recognized that I did Charlie Calello, that recognized that -- I didn't know that I had a sound but there were other people that identified the sound. So now if you have that consistency it's very, very difficult to then come out of that box and suddenly try to make a twist. Now I didn't know I was really doing that when I went through the process. I appreciated that I had made that adjustment in the way I made records.

MR: I had a quote from you from our conversation a year ago on the phone, you said, "We never got out of the sound box." But I can't remember what the context was. I think you're talking about that. And were you referring to – Linda Ronstadt did a –

CC: Right. Yeah. Nelson Riddle did the Ronstadt record.

MR: I think it's very interesting that other people heard that you had a sound but you weren't aware of it. It's almost like critics naming styles of music but the musicians don't know. I mean not that they don't know but musicians were playing bebop but they didn't call it bebop until the critics did.

CC: Yeah. It was sort of – I think you know taking into consideration, you mentioned something very, very early on about how rewarding it was to write arrangements. But there was also a – it was – I recognized that my career would probably only last maybe twenty, thirty years. And I had an office in the '60s at Al Gallico's office. You may not know who Al Gallico was but he was a publisher and he published "Stand By Your Man" and he was basically Billy – oh I can't remember his name now. But every day Hugo Winterhalter used to come in and sit down in his office and hang out with Al. Now I grew up listening to Hugo Winterhalter who was a key arranger on RCA Victor. But while I was making all these records and I was doing record after record, he didn't have work. And the reason why he didn't have work, the music style had changed. And as it changed they didn't have the opportunity to make the change because they were stuck in this old bag. And they no longer spoke the language. Now when I started to make The Four Seasons records the studio musicians didn't speak the pop language. They had to be taught.

MR: The straight eighths.

CC: They didn't want to overdub. They were used to doing the whole thing. They didn't want to wear earphones. They couldn't play with earphones. It was a lot – it was very, very different. Now here we come along and we're sort of changing the face of the way that music was working. So I figured that there would come a time when I would not speak the language anymore. So after I had my run with Juice Newton and I had a couple of country hits in the '80s, I actually had my last chart record in the '90s. And when I left to

because the only business I knew was the record business. Little did I know, my wife was smart enough to know that I wasn't going to stop writing, so she donated my services to the Pops orchestra and then I started to see the acts come in, they needed arrangements. And I'm saying to myself how come I didn't know about this?

MR: And now you've got a big band to write for.

CC: Yeah. And well the orchestrations changed and a lot of things changed. But the other thing about the insecurity of not being current – every time you write an arrangement you're showing up to the date naked. You're letting it all hang out. You don't know if they're going to like it, they're not going to like it, and there's always something you know you did wrong. And it got to the point where I really didn't have a good understanding about where I was as an arranger until many, many years later.

MR: Did you ever have a circumstance – you're talking about writing for a pops orchestra – arranging something you had done years before but you never had to notate and include the melody because someone was singing it? And then you're writing for a pops orchestra with let's say a medley and no one is singing, all of a sudden it's like, "Wow, I never wrote out 'Sherry Baby' before, the actual melody of it."

CC: Well when I wrote the arrangements I always wrote the melody on the top line unless I was sweetening a record where they already had the singer on, where all I had to do was just write the parts. But when I started a session the first thing I do is I write out the melody. I want to know what the melody is, and then I write out the basic chords, and then I'll change the chords as I go along but I do a basic layout of just the song. Because every time I start an arrangement I start with a blank page. So I've recently listened to four albums I did over the past couple of years and I'd say, "How did I come up with this? Where did I get this idea?" And it puzzles me every time I do it. But as I'm writing the melody down there's things that I'm picking up in my brain as I'm doing it and there's just, for some reason I think by writing the melody it gives me an opportunity to at least get an idea as to where this thing is going to go. And for some reason there's a way of putting it together where you don't have to write the same intro, it's always different, and you wonder where it's going to come from but it always seems to come.

MR: Do you have to step away sometimes and go do something else? Go for a walk and let your head work the thing out on its own?

CC: Well I recently did another record with Joe Bwarie which was a lot of fun. And he wanted to do "I Only Have Eyes for You." And he wanted it to sound like a pop record. And I love Bruno Mars. So I worked on the arrangement for three weeks until I came up with the idea. I worked on the song for three weeks, and I finally came up with it. And I think the record is absolutely sensational, although very few people will hear it. But it

together it's a totally different record, different song, but it was something like I said I don't have it yet.

MR: It wasn't talking to you yet.

CC: Yeah. It wasn't saying, "Hey Charlie, it needs this." But eventually it did. So if you want to get a chance to listen to it, it's on Joe Bwarie's "Lucky 13" new album and it's "I Only Have Eyes for You" now. Then after I made the record, I turned the record over to a synth programmer who took my arrangement and tweaked it and made it in some ways better, in some ways the same, but it's the essence of the record. Because of all the backgrounds, the lead, the layout, everything – the chord structure, the feel, everything else and it was all me. And I sort of listened to the record and I said, "That was a hard record to make."

MR: Right. Well this has just been a delight for me, as an arranger myself I'm very envious of your career. And another quote – one more quote from you. "I was one of the cogs in the wheel of record producing." You were a large cog I think.

CC: Well you know the position that arrangers have, it's sort of like the drummer who gets the groove on a record, and a bass player who reads the notes but makes it feel like it's in the pocket. Any one of those guys missing could alter the outcome. And when you're working with a team and you're a cog in the wheel, you're one of the ones that's making that wheel turn. Now in some cases yeah you play a more major part than this person over here or that person over there. But in essence pretty much everything we do as arrangers, we're standing on somebody's shoulders. So as far as our being original, we never really take total credit for being original because as John Lennon once said, "The difference between professionals and amateurs, amateurs copy and professionals steal." The thing about writing, in my mind I want the rhythm section to sound like a Diana Krall record, I want the horns to sound like a Basie record, and I want the strings to sound like Nelson wrote them. Now how do I put that together? So you're constantly picking pieces and regurgitating them back to the paper. So, in your brain you're a cog. I don't know if that makes any sense.

MR: I think it does, and it's all worked for you. And I want to thank you for your time today. It's enlightening and I know people are going to dig it.

CC: Well one of the things I'm glad took place with this interview, you didn't ask me about any of the records and how do you go about doing this, how do you go about doing that, but some of the things that I'm more proud of that I've done recently, if you get a chance to actually get a chance to listen, I mentioned a Ronnie Milsap record – I did that twenty years ago but I still love the arrangements I wrote on Ronnie's record. I only wrote six of the arrangements. I split the date with Sammy Nestico, which was a thrill for me. Also,

that some of the arrangements in that were – they're all old pop tunes, but some of the arrangements were very, very cleverly constructed and we went through a process working with a couple of people that fed ideas into it and it's all explained on the record. But the most joy has been over the past years not chasing the market but just writing what I really wanted to write.

MR: And you well deserve that.

CC: Thank you. Well it was really nice doing this. I. really, really enjoyed it. Thanks for inviting me.

MR: All right. I'll pause here and then we'll say our good-byes, Charles.

CC: Okay. Good-bye.